IELTS ACADEMIC · RESTRICTED STAFF MATERIAL

IELTS Academic Set 25

PRIVATE STAFF answer key and Listening transcript

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Answer keys and Listening transcripts are restricted to staff.

Listening

Question	Answer	Accepted variants
1	Willowbank	
2	duplex	
3	bedroom	
4	blower door	
5	email	
6	5 days	five days
7	B	
8	B	
9	C	
10	A	
11	B	
12	E	
13	A	
14	D	
15	F	
16	C	
17	H	
18	A	
19	D	

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Question	Answer	Accepted variants
20	G	
21	D	
22	A	
23	F	
24	C	
25	G	
26	B	
27	C	
28	A	
29	B	
30	C	
31	canopy	
32	resin	
33	soften	
34	exposed	
35	minerals	
36	maturity	
37	wind	
38	method agreement	
39	protective structures	
40	seedling counts	

Listening transcript

Part 1 - Everyday social dialogue: booking a home heat-loss survey in Halifax, Nova Scotia

Jonah Pike	Good morning, Harbour Home Energy. Jonah speaking. We run non-invasive heat-loss surveys for tenants and owners. How can I help you today?
Maren Caldwell	Hi. I rent an older house and one room is noticeably colder. I would like to arrange a survey before the weather becomes milder.
Jonah Pike	Certainly. I will take the booking details first and then discuss appointments. The assessor will describe likely leakage paths, but the visit is not a quotation for building work and no contractor is recommended.
Maren Caldwell	I started the online form but was unsure whether my landlord had to complete it.

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Jonah Pike	We can settle that in a moment. First, what is the property address? Please include the house number and spell the street name.
Maren Caldwell	It is 46 Willowbank Road. That is Willowbank as one word. The postcode is B3K 2R8, not B3K 2B, which people sometimes enter.
Jonah Pike	Thank you. Our map may be out of date. What type of building are you actually in?
Maren Caldwell	It is a duplex, with our entrance on the left. It has three storeys if you count the finished room under the roof. The two households share the central wall, although the loft room and its small dormer window belong entirely to our side.
Jonah Pike	Which area feels most uncomfortable? I need the precise room rather than the general side of the house.
Maren Caldwell	The kitchen is cool, but the clear draught is in the upstairs bedroom. You can feel it beside the window when the wind comes from the harbour.
Jonah Pike	The assessor begins with a visual check and a thermal camera. If conditions allow, the pressure test is called a blower door test. The fan sits in an external doorway for only a short period, while the camera records where outside air is entering.
Maren Caldwell	Nothing has to be drilled or removed, does it? The lease says I must get approval before anyone makes a permanent change to the property.
Jonah Pike	No permanent change is made. We still require the owner’s consent because doors and vents are temporarily managed during the test. Written permission is enough.
Maren Caldwell	I have my landlord’s email saying the survey may go ahead. I can forward it today, rather than asking him to sign another form.
Jonah Pike	That will work. The report includes labelled images and practical observations. We normally send it electronically within 5 days of the visit. It separates straightforward draught sealing from larger issues that may need the owner to commission a specialist inspection.
Maren Caldwell	Good. I am comparing times because I need quiet during scheduled work calls.
Jonah Pike	Tuesday at four was available earlier, but another customer has just taken it. Saturday at eleven remains open, although no technician can bring the pressure equipment then.
Jonah Pike	The full survey is available on Thursday at 9:30, and there is also a Thursday afternoon visit at two, when the outdoor temperature may be less useful. That morning slot is also long enough for the camera survey, pressure test and a brief explanation of the initial observations.
Maren Caldwell	Then book Thursday at 9:30. I considered Saturday because it is convenient, but I want the complete set of checks rather than the shorter visit.
Jonah Pike	Morning is helpful mainly because the temperature difference between indoors and outdoors is usually strongest. It gives the camera a clearer contrast. We do not need extreme cold; a stable contrast is more useful than a sudden temperature change during the appointment.
Maren Caldwell	Understood. Do I need to turn the heating off, close every vent, or do anything else before the assessor arrives?
Jonah Pike	Keep the house at its normal setting. You may leave ordinary vents alone. The useful preparation is to clear exterior walls by moving large furniture a short distance away. Please keep internal doors accessible as well, because the assessor compares pressure changes between the main rooms before checking individual windows.

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Maren Caldwell	I can move the bookcase the night before and mention the unused fireplace when the assessor comes.
Jonah Pike	Excellent. There is no deposit. After the visit, we email a secure link, and you pay online once the survey has been completed. The confirmation explains the fixed fee and states that payment does not become due if weather makes the survey unsuitable.
Maren Caldwell	That suits me. I will reply to the confirmation with the consent email.
Jonah Pike	Done. It will arrive shortly with Thursday's time and our telephone number.

Part 2 - Everyday social monologue: orientation at a cargo-bike lending hub in Bristol

Asha Penrose	Welcome to the East Dock cargo-bike hub. I am Asha, today's coordinator. Before anyone rides, I will explain how the four service areas operate and then guide you around the courtyard practice circuit. Keep the printed plan upright, with the north arrow pointing away from you.
Asha Penrose	At the check-in desk, please show your booking code. We do not keep bank cards as security. The volunteer finds your loan record, confirms an emergency contact, and gives you the numbered key for the assigned bike.
Asha Penrose	The battery locker is beside the staff office. Members sometimes assume they can collect a spare themselves, but that space is staff only. Ask at the desk if the charge seems low; a volunteer will exchange the unit.
Asha Penrose	The loading bay has floor scales. Weigh the cargo before loading it, then place heavier items low and centrally. Tighten the straps only after the load is balanced, because different models distribute weight differently.
Asha Penrose	At the child-seat station, begin with the demonstration doll, even if you regularly use another bicycle. The instructor checks the buckle height and foot guards. No child enters the circuit until that fitting exercise is complete.
Asha Penrose	Now turn to the courtyard plan. You enter through the gate along the southern edge. A red post box stands immediately to your right, but it belongs to the neighbouring depot and is outside our route. Keep the check-in building on your left and walk past its projecting corner. The cabinet is fixed there, immediately past the building corner. Notice that this is before the first crossing, not beside the gate itself.
Asha Penrose	From the cabinet, follow the one-way arrows across the bottom of the courtyard. You pass the near side of the helmet rack, but do not stop there because its access point faces the opposite direction. Continue until the outer wall turns north. The rainwater tap is mounted at the far south-east corner, directly on that turn.
Asha Penrose	Next, turn north beside the painted bicycle symbol. A wide storage door appears on your left and normally remains locked. Look across the route rather than beside the door: the repair stand is on the inner wall directly opposite that storage door. Today you will practise lifting only the front wheel while a volunteer steadies the bicycle.
Asha Penrose	Continue around the top of the courtyard until you see the striped rectangle that represents the loading bay described earlier. The helmet rack is just beyond the striped loading bay, still along the northern edge, where riders can stop without blocking the scales.

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Asha Penrose	After choosing a helmet, follow the curve around the child-seat loop. A small waiting shelter stands inside that loop. It is a landmark, not one of the destinations named in your questions. The battery-return hatch is fixed to the shelter's outer wall, on the eastern side where riders can reach it without entering the seating area.
Asha Penrose	The arrows next lead south between two large planters. Keep past the blue staff-room door and within the marked line. Do not leave the circuit at that door: it belongs to staff and is not a public exit. Continue until the path turns.
Asha Penrose	Two other marked points on the plan help you orient yourself: one is beside the covered drain in the north-east corner, and the other is by that old delivery bell on the west wall. Neither is a destination in this exercise. They remain visible because, on a real circuit, you must distinguish a landmark that you pass from the place where you are asked to stop.
Asha Penrose	During the circuit, use the lowest assistance setting and leave one bicycle length between riders. Practise a straight stop before turning with a load. If the bike leans, put both feet down; this exercise is about control. On the second circuit, the observer should watch whether the rider checks over a shoulder before moving away from each station, rather than judging speed.
Asha Penrose	Finally, loans remain within the marked city zone shown on your membership card. Before departure, check the brakes, tyre condition, straps and lights with a volunteer. Report a fault instead of adjusting electrical parts yourself, and return through the exit gate at the agreed time. If your planned route changes, you do not need permission, provided the bicycle remains inside the zone and you meet the booked return time.
Asha Penrose	We will now form pairs. One person walks the first circuit while the other observes the arrows, and then you exchange roles. Leave the bicycles on their stands until a volunteer calls your pair, so the first group has room to practise the turn by the shelter. When both riders have completed the circuit, follow the southbound path beyond the planters. The exit gate is at the boundary with the quiet service lane. Stop before the line, check for pedestrians and leave only when the lane is clear.

Part 3 - Educational discussion: trainee pharmacists review incomplete simulated handover cards in Glasgow

Iona Kerr	We have five simulated handover cards to reconcile before tomorrow's assessed session. I thought we could correct the obvious errors tonight and leave only the difficult ones for the facilitator.
Lewis Muir	That is my concern. The exercise tests how we respond to incomplete sources, not whether we can make the cards look tidy by guessing what was intended.
Iona Kerr	Card One has a complete medicine list but a blank allergy field. At first I copied "no known allergies" from the previous practice case, then realised that record belonged to a different fictional patient.
Lewis Muir	We could ask the actor at the start, though the brief says the actor may not have every source detail.
Iona Kerr	Then we should pause and request the missing source from the facilitator. We can mark the field as unresolved while we wait, and the log should show who requested it.
Lewis Muir	Card Two is different. The admission list gives ten milligrams, while the simulated discharge note gives five.

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Iona Kerr	Exactly. We should record both values and escalate before merging the lists. The discrepancy itself is important evidence, so the final training record should retain both doses, their sources and the unresolved status.
Lewis Muir	On Card Three the medicine name is partly illegible. The ending resembles a familiar product and the dose looks plausible, but that combination could fit more than one item. We should request a clearer source instead of inferring the name, and note exactly which document cannot be read.
Iona Kerr	Agreed. We can describe the location of the unclear entry without offering a possible name, because even a tentative suggestion could influence the person who checks it next.
Lewis Muir	Card Four lists prescribed medicines but says nothing about non-prescription products. We should ask a structured question in the simulated interview, including prompts about painkillers, herbal products and supplements.
Iona Kerr	Yes, and the wording should stay neutral. We can ask what the person takes without suggesting that a particular product is expected.
Lewis Muir	The final card places a brand name and a generic name on separate lines. Their tablet descriptions differ, so they look like two medicines, but we should check the active ingredient before we classify a duplication.
Iona Kerr	That gives us five different responses rather than one blanket rule. Missing source, conflicting doses, illegible name, absent interview detail and possible duplication each need a distinct action.
Lewis Muir	For tomorrow’s sequence, I originally suggested starting with the medicine list because it is the longest section and would get us moving.
Iona Kerr	So our first action must be to confirm the simulated patient’s identity across all three sources. Only after the identifiers agree do we compare medicines.
Lewis Muir	Now the escalation log. Colour coding may make serious discrepancies stand out on screen, but it creates printing and accessibility problems and still leaves responsibility unclear. Each entry needs an owner, initials and a time, together with the source involved, so another trainee can see who must follow it up.
Iona Kerr	We could retain a small priority symbol as a secondary aid, provided the text carries the meaning. The owner field matters more because a red box with nobody assigned can remain untouched. I will also include a status column so open items are not confused with resolved ones.
Lewis Muir	What about interview roles? One option is for the more confident speaker to lead all five cases while the other checks documents. That would make the delivery consistent, but it would give the observer almost no practice and could make one style seem like the only acceptable approach.
Iona Kerr	Let us alternate the lead after each case. The observer can use the same checklist, note anything that needs clarification, and wait until a natural pause before contributing. Alternating gives us comparable experience without turning the interview into two people competing to ask the next question.
Lewis Muir	For the debrief, I do not want to focus on the total number of mistakes. A count can show that the cards differed, but it cannot explain why one assumption was unsafe or why we chose escalation in one case and a structured interview question in another.

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Iona Kerr	Then the main focus should be the reasoning behind each decision. We can select two contrasting cases and explain the evidence we had, the tempting shortcut we rejected and what information changed the outcome. That will reveal judgement more clearly than either speed or a bar chart of errors.
Lewis Muir	We also need to decide what evidence to retain. The final reconciled list shows the outcome, and screenshots preserve its appearance, but neither tells a later reviewer which source contained the discrepancy or why an entry was changed. A neat final page could therefore conceal a weak process.
Iona Kerr	A later reviewer must reconstruct why an entry changed. The final list plus a brief comment might not show the original source, the discrepancy or the action that followed. We need a record that makes that sequence visible without relying on memory.
Lewis Muir	I agree. Screenshots preserve appearance but not which source supported a decision. I will prepare the role rotation and neutral checklist, and label every page as simulation material. None of these entries can support a real clinical decision; that boundary belongs on the documents.
Iona Kerr	Then we will retain an audit trail linking each source, discrepancy and action, together with the person and time associated with the decision. I will test whether another trainee can reconstruct one case using only that log. Tomorrow we also confirm identity first, keep uncertainties visible, alternate the lead and explain our reasoning in the debrief.
Lewis Muir	That gives the assessor evidence of safe process as well as communication. I will send the revised plan tonight and ask the facilitator only for source documents we genuinely need, rather than asking for decisions that belong to us.

Part 4 - Academic monologue: serotinous seed release and post-fire recruitment in Melbourne

Lecturer	Today we examine serotiny, a strategy in which a plant retains mature seeds instead of releasing them immediately. In several fire-prone shrubs and trees, the seeds remain above ground in a canopy seed bank, enclosed within woody cones or follicles.
Lecturer	Retention depends on structure. In many examples, the valves surrounding a seed are held shut by resin. Ordinary warmth may not open the fruit. During a fire, however, a stronger heat pulse causes the resin to soften and the dry valves separate. Species vary, so this is not a universal rule for every serotinous plant. This threshold is commonly described as heat-triggered opening, but researchers measure it across a range rather than assuming a single temperature applies to every fruit.
Lecturer	Thick woody walls shield the seed during brief heating, and air spaces within the fruit reduce direct exposure. Protection has limits: an exceptionally severe fire can kill seeds, while old fruits may no longer seal them effectively. Retained seed number and viability are therefore separate measurements. Moisture content also matters: a dry structure can transmit heat differently from one exposed to recent rain, so comparable trials record both heating conditions and fruit state.
Lecturer	Opening is often delayed until the fruit cools. By then, fire may have removed foliage around the parent and created more exposed ground. Dry winds can then carry light, often winged seeds away. This does not guarantee a long journey; it only places release when movement and landing may be favourable.

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Lecturer	Fire consumes litter unevenly, exposing patches of mineral soil. That surface can give small seeds firmer contact than a deep layer of leaves. Ash may return minerals to the upper soil, although it is not a complete fertiliser and not every species benefits. Small depressions in that mineral surface may trap seed, whereas exposed ridges can lose it to wind or runoff before roots develop.
Lecturer	Light conditions also change. Canopy removal reduces shade and temporarily lowers competition. The same opening can raise surface temperatures and water loss. Recruitment therefore depends on interacting light, moisture and temperature, and rain arriving soon after release may be decisive. Thus an open patch offers opportunity and stress at the same time; the balance can change within days as weather and neighbouring vegetation respond.
Lecturer	Researchers compare several stages. They count closed and open fruits, test extracted seeds under controlled conditions, and after a burn establish plots and make seedling counts. Repeated counts matter because initial germination may be followed by high mortality in the first dry season. Researchers often tag the same plots so that emergence, early survival and later establishment are not confused as if they were a single measure.
Lecturer	The age of the parent population creates another limit. If fires return too frequently, young plants may burn before reaching maturity and replenishing the canopy store. Each event can then leave fewer seeds than the one before. At the opposite extreme, very long intervals may allow fruits to deteriorate, predators to remove seed, or adult plants to die without a suitable release event. The important interval is therefore biological, not simply chronological: it must allow enough adults to reproduce and enough viable seed to accumulate before the next disturbance.
Lecturer	The phrase “adapted to fire” needs qualification. Serotiny can improve reproductive timing under a particular regime, but it does not make a plant resistant to every intensity or frequency. Stored seed and post-fire weather must together permit population replacement.
Lecturer	Spatial variation is equally important. One slope may burn completely while a neighbouring hollow remains patchy. Fruits on the unburned plant may stay closed, yet seeds released from a burned edge can travel into both areas. Sampling only the blackened centre could therefore overstate the uniformity of opening and miss the contribution of nearby surviving adults. A sound design samples across that gradient and records burn severity at each point, allowing dispersal and local opening to be interpreted separately.
Lecturer	Scientists can separate heat effects from smoke or chemical cues in experiments, but field interpretation remains cautious. A laboratory oven controls temperature precisely while excluding wind, flame and changing humidity. A field fire includes all of these. Method agreement across laboratory tests, field fruit counts and later recruitment surveys is stronger evidence than one method alone. The comparison is strongest when each method tests a clearly stated stage, such as valve opening, seed viability, arrival at the ground or establishment.
Lecturer	There are also evolutionary questions. Retaining seed carries costs because the plant invests in protective structures and risks losing several years of reproduction in one destructive event. The benefit is concentrated release into a relatively open seedbed. Whether that trade-off is favourable depends on the historical pattern of fire and on how reliably new plants establish afterward. In other words, the strategy shifts risk through time: many small release events are replaced by a stored investment that may meet one unusually favourable disturbance.

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Lecturer	Climate change can affect both sides of the sequence. Hotter droughts may reduce seed production before a fire, while altered fire seasons can change the interval between burns. Heavy rain after release may support emergence, but intense runoff can also move ash and seed away from suitable microsites. Predictions should therefore state which stage of the life cycle a climate effect concerns. Models that combine all these effects into a single “fire benefit” can therefore hide opposing pressures on production, release, movement and survival.
Lecturer	For assessment, remember the chain rather than a slogan: a canopy store accumulates; heat may soften resin; woody walls provide partial protection; the fruit opens; dry winds assist dispersal; and exposed ground receives the seed. Ash can add minerals, while canopy removal changes light and competition. None of those steps alone demonstrates successful population recovery.
Lecturer	The final evidence must extend beyond emergence. Researchers return to marked plots for follow-up seedling counts after the first seasonal stress, then compare survival with fruit and germination data. That longer record shows whether the apparent reproductive opportunity produced established young plants rather than only a brief carpet of seedlings. Establishment is usually defined by a pre-declared survival point, so investigators do not select a convenient date after seeing the result.
Lecturer	Serotiny is therefore best understood as conditional timing. It links stored reproduction to disturbance, but its outcome remains bounded by fire severity, fire interval, weather, seedbed variation and survival after germination.

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Reading

Question	Answer	Accepted variants
1	iii	
2	vi	
3	ii	
4	vii	
5	i	
6	v	
7	iv	
8	sloping ground	ground
9	ponds	
10	straw	
11	air lock	
12	sump	
13	ships	
14	FALSE	
15	TRUE	
16	FALSE	
17	NOT GIVEN	
18	TRUE	
19	FALSE	
20	NOT GIVEN	
21	A	
22	F	
23	E	
24	C	
25	D	
26	G	
27	YES	
28	NO	

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Question	Answer	Accepted variants
29	NOT GIVEN	
30	YES	
31	NO	
32	YES	
33	NOT GIVEN	
34	H	
35	C	
36	E	
37	B	
38	G	
39	A	
40	F	

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